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CHAPTER XII

FREMONT AND THE WINTER OF 1854

John Charles Fremont was a man of multifaceted talent. His most monumental success came as an explorer in the West, although he had been a California Senator, a Civil War general, a presidential aspirant and the Territorial Governor of Arizona. He led men across the plains and Rockies under conditions of hardship and privation five times and, through narratives, publicized the West to a nation hungry to know about this vast wilderness. He was the first to describe and explain the great climatic and geological differences between the east and the west. His greatest contribution to Utah was the discovery and naming of the Great Basin as a geologic and geographical entity. Because he explored the area's perimeters, he discovered that, although large streams flowed in, no rivers ran from the area to the sea. His perceptive analysis of this phenomenon was the first recognition of the great power of evaporation in the region. He also established the correct elevation of the Great Salt Lake at 4,200 feet. After extensively exploring the lake, his party boiled down five gallons of lake water and produced fourteen pints of very white and fine-grained salt.

An exploring expedition required organization and, as a leader, Fremont provided this. He handled logistics, oversaw the mapping, conducted the geodetic surveying, arranged the defense and

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maintained the records. He regarded it as routine to take readings on the stars late at night, sometimes standing waist-deep in snow. His maps were used by thousands of immigrants on their travels to Oregon and California. Fremont's report containing the description of the Great Basin was submitted to the Chief of the Bureau of Topographical Engineers in 1845 and ordered by Congress to be printed. The publication was very popular. Fremont's descriptions of the topography of the west were undoubtedly influential in the Saint's decision to settle in the Salt Lake Valley.¹

Fremont launched an expedition in October 1848, to establish the feasibility of a railroad to the Pacific, which terminated in disaster in the snows of the San Juans in Colorado. In 1853 Congress appropriated money for five Pacific railroad surveys. Failing to land a spot at the head of one of these surveys, Fremont decided to go on another winter expedition at his own expense. He wanted to show that winter snow was not a deterrent to such a railroad route and, in the process, cover himself with glory. He recruited a party of twenty-two men. The expedition included the American-born, Jewish-Portuguese artist and daguerreotypist, Solomon Nunes Carvalho, whose narrative is the only source of detail about this adventure. Ten Delaware Indians were among the party. "A more noble set of Indians I never saw," wrote Carvalho, "the most of them six feet high, all mounted and armed."

The expedition got underway on Sept. 22, 1853, from the St. Louis area. They traveled up the Arkansas River, worked their way over the Rockies and down the western slope into Utah. Before reaching the Green River, they diverged south and crossed the river near the mouth of the San Rafael and wandered through unexplored country to Circle Valley on the Sevier River, and ultimately reached Parowan in the southwest corner of the present state of Utah. Carvalho chronicles vividly the sufferings of the little party as they doggedly pushed through the wintry wilderness, sometimes encountering raging snowstorms with temperatures as low as thirty degrees below zero. On one occasion the lead mule slipped on a snowy mountain slope and tumbled, head over heels, several hundred feet to the bottom of a canyon, carrying fifty other mules with him.

Fortunately, only one mule was killed, but it took a full day to recover the baggage. The crossing of the east fork of the Colorado River was attended with much difficulty and more danger.

Steadily the expedition's food supply dwindled and couldn't be replenished on a regular basis, because of lack of available game. Once they had a beaver for breakfast, a porcupine for supper, and a coyote for another meal. They collected cactus leaves and ate them by burning off the spines in the fire. Soon it became necessary to kill their horses for food, at which point Fremont called the men together and exacted a solemn pledge that, regardless of the extremity, they would not resort to cannibalism, as some may have done on a previous expedition.

Some of the men began to lag behind as suffering became more acute. Finally, Fremont ordered them to leave all the extra baggage behind so they could ride the horses and mules. During that night in Circle Valley, standing almost to their waist in snow for hours, he and Carvalho made astronomical observations. The veteran explorer concluded that Parowan, the small Mormon settlement only forty rods square, was three days travel away. Reaching it was a feat in itself, and almost at the very hour of triumph near Mule Point, one of their men, Oliver Fuller, died in the saddle. They arrived in Parowan on February 8, 1854, and the Mormons opened their homes to these dirty, half-starved men.

Fremont stayed with Stake President J. C. L. Smith's family and Carvalho stayed with the English shoemaker, William Heap and his family. The secretary of the territory, Almon W. Babbitt, had stopped in this walled village of a hundred families en route to Washington, by way of California, and Fremont was able, not only to borrow money from him, but to send letters home with his company. Fremont continued his journey the last of February and arrived in San Francisco in mid April.² Carvalho, too weak to continue, remained in Iron County and wrote the following about the expedition:

I was ill; I was so much enervated by diarrhea that my physician advised me not to accompany the expedition, as the exertion of riding on horseback

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would have completely prostrated me. My digestive organs were so much weakened and impaired by the irregular living on horse meat without salt or vegetables that I was fearful that I should never recover. I left for Great Salt Lake City in a wagon belonging to one of a large company of Mormons who were on their way to 'Conference.' I was so weak that I had to be lifted in and out of the wagon like a child. To the kind attentions of Mr. Henry Lunt, President of Cedar City, Coal Creek, and his lady, I was indebted for some necessities such as sugar, tea, and coffee which it was impossible to purchase. They also offered me the use of their wagon which was better adapted to an invalid than the one I occupied.

After 10 days, passing through all the different Mormon settlements on the road, we arrived at Great Salt Lake City on the night of the 1st of March 1854. I called on Governor Young and was received by him with marked attention. He tendered me the use of all his philosophical instruments and access to a large and valuable library.

The city is immediately at the base of a high range of mountains. An adobe wall twelve feet high, six feet at the base tapering upwards to 2 ½ feet, entirely surrounds the city enclosing an immense area of ground for pasturage, etc., thus protecting the people and cattle from the aggression of Indians. Most of the dwelling houses are built a little distance from the sidewalk, and to each dwelling is appropriated an acre and a quarter of ground for gardening purposes. I may say, all the real estate in the valley is the property of the Church, for the proprietors have only an interest in property so long as they are members of the Mormon Church and reside in the valley.

During a residence of ten weeks in Great Salt Lake City and my observations in all their various

settlements, amongst a homogeneous population of over seventy-five thousand inhabitants, it is worthy to record that I never heard any obscene or improper language; never saw a man drunk; never had my attention called to the exhibition of vice of any sort. There were no gambling houses, grog shops, or buildings of ill fame in all their settlements. They preach morality in their churches from their stands and what is as strange as it is true, the people practice it.³

Among the conference group were some of Henry Lunt's friends --President John C. L. Smith, Col. James A. Little, Major John D. Lee, Samuel West, and James H. Marteneau. Henry and Ellen received their endowments in the Endowment House while in Salt Lake City on March 8, 1854. They were sealed by George A. Smith eight months after their marriage and now, two years later, received their endowments.⁴

There were approximately 7,000 members present at Conference where President Heber C. Kimball conducted and spoke of plural marriage, declaring its divine origin. "Many of you have fought it," he said, "You may continue to fight it until you go down into your graves, and it will still continue to be the work of God and will still continue through all eternity."⁵

Erastus Snow was called on a mission to St. Louis and Orson Pratt to Cincinnati during one of the meetings. Also, a dozen men were called to go on missions to England, but were not to leave until summer. Those called were: Franklin D. Richards, James A. Little, George D. Grant, Joseph A. Young, William H. Kimball, William G. Young, Edmund Ellsworth, Henry Lunt, William G. Walker, Robert W. Wolcott, Benjamin Waldron and Cyrus H. Wheelock.⁶

Carvalho, determined to go to California by the southern route, completed his arrangements and decided to proceed, by invitation, with the party of Governor Young who usually paid an annual visit to each of the different settlements to the south. The group consisted of a large number of wagons and mounted horsemen. They left Salt Lake City on May 5, 1854. Carvalho's account continues:

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We entered Parowan about 5 o'clock, May 17, and I was affectionately greeted by those persons who administered to my sufferings some weeks before. I had changed so much and grown so fat that not one of them knew me. Mrs. Heap, my old landlady, could not believe I was the ugly, emaciated person whose face she washed only three months before. Parowan contains one hundred families, five hundred head of cattle, one hundred and fifty horses and mules, and three hundred sheep. John C. L. Smith is President. Lewis is Bishop, and John Steele is Mayor.

Our party arrived at Cedar City, Coal Creek at 2 o'clock on the 18th. Mr. Henry Lunt, a well-informed and generous-hearted Englishman was, it is supposed, the first white man who ever entered this valley or the river of the Great basin [to stay] with twenty-two men. He arrived at the present site of the city two years and a half ago to form a settlement. Cedar City now contains one thousand inhabitants, fifteen hundred head of cattle, and a large number of horses, mules and sheep.

The city is half a mile square and completely surrounded by an adobe wall twelve feet high, six feet at the base, and two and a half at the top; the building of the wall was attended by a great deal of labor. The persevering industry of these people is unsurpassed. A temple block is in the center of the city covering twenty acres of ground. The building lots are each twenty rods by four rods. The Iron Works are in successful operation, and all the railroad iron necessary to complete a road from there to San Bernardino can be procured here.

This city is destined to become a great place of business and, in case the Pacific Railroad does not come through or near Great Salt Lake City, it will be the channel through which all importations for the

Territory of Utah will come, it being only about four hundred and fifty miles from San Diego on the Pacific coast, a distance frequently traveled in ten days.

I renewed my acquaintance with the President, Henry Lunt, with much pleasure, and I remained at his house during my stay and, to himself and kind lady (they are among those who deprecate the spiritual wife system), I was indebted for many little attentions and civilities. Mr. Lunt was about visiting the city of New York on his way to England, and I gave him a letter of introduction to my family which he delivered afterwards in person before I arrived home.

Years later in 1888, while living in Arizona, Fremont was asked to introduce Kate Field, an actress and journalist, who was lecturing on the vices and evils of Mormonism. Fremont refused to take part in this public meeting. "I cannot do it," he said, "The Mormons saved me and mine from death by starvation in '54."⁷

1. Utah Historical Society, "Fremont Expedition of 1853," *Utah Historical Quarterly*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: 1976), p. 295.
2. *Ibid*, p. 299.
3. S. N. Carvalho, *Travel and Adventure in The Far West*, S.U.U. Special Collections Library, Cedar City, Utah, p. 143.
4. John G. Chatterley, "Family Group Sheet," Lunt Genealogy Research.
5. Matthias F. Cowley, *Wilford Woodruff, History of His Life*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Bookcraft, 1964) p. 356.
6. *Millennial Star*, Magazine Collection, July 1854 ed., L. D. S. Institute Library, Cedar City, Utah, Page 460.
7. Utah Historical Society, *op. cit.*, p. 302.

